

Chapter 17 — Critique

Attacking your own argument before a reviewer does

Chapter 4 verified a prompt. Chapter 14 verified a source. This verifies an argument.

Ask for the harshest defensible report

- Not "what do you think of this" — that invites the trained behaviour Chapter 3 warned you about.
- "Write the harshest referee report this methodology can sustain. For each objection, state what evidence would answer it."
- The second sentence is what makes it useful. An objection with no stated remedy is noise.

Notice this is the anti-pattern slide from Chapter 3, run deliberately in reverse: you are asking for analysis instead of a verdict, on purpose, about your own work.

What it is good at, and what it is not

Good at

- Objections that are standard in a field
- Missing controls, unstated assumptions
- Internal inconsistency between sections
- The question a reader will ask that you stopped seeing

Not good at

- Whether the result is actually true
- Whether the objection matters more than the finding
- Anything requiring the data it cannot see
- Deciding which criticism to act on

It generates candidate objections. **Ranking them is yours**, and ranking is where the judgement lives.

Rebuttal letters

- Draft, then stress-test the draft: give it the reviewer's comment and your reply, and ask where the reply does not actually answer the comment.
- The common failure is answering a weaker version of the objection. That is easy to do and hard to see in your own writing.
- Keep the tone yours. A rebuttal in a voice that is not yours reads as a rebuttal written by someone who is not accountable for it.

Language support, and where the boundary sits

- For a group where English is a second language for several people, this is among the highest-value uses in the course.
- Grammar, register and clarity are edits to expression. The claim, the interpretation and the responsibility remain entirely yours.
- **The boundary is not about how much text changed.** It is about whether the meaning is still the one you decided on.

Where a disclosure is required, disclose. Chapter 18 makes that concrete against the actual policies you write under.

The detection question, from both sides

Chapter 5 said AI-text detectors are unreliable in both directions, and that their false positives fall disproportionately on non-native English writers — **seven detectors, as tested in March 2023**. The direction is well evidenced; the specific rates are a snapshot of products that have since changed.

- **From your side:** you use language support and someone accuses you. You cannot prove authorship from the text itself — which is why the answer is never textual.
- **From the other side:** you suspect a student's text and have no reliable instrument.
- These are the same question, and the honest answer to both is the same: **the detector is not evidence.**

What protects you is process, not proof: version history, drafts, notes, and a disclosure you wrote before anyone asked. Chapter 18 turns that into a lab standard.

Threads

- **Verification** — prompts in Chapter 4, sources in Chapter 14, arguments here. Chapter 18 closes it as logging and reproducibility.
- **Detection** — introduced as a Chapter 5 limitation, met here as a practical problem with a procedural answer.

Exercise

1. Take a section of your own current writing.
2. Ask for the harshest defensible referee report, with evidence requirements attached to each objection.
3. Rank the objections yourself. Discard the ones that do not matter and say why.
4. Answer the top one, properly, before you leave.

Step 3 is the chapter. Anyone can generate criticism; the skill is deciding which criticism is load-bearing.